actually extends parts of the language itself—leads to a distinction in the Ruby community between "Ruby developers" and "Rails developers."

This philosophy is entirely different in Phoenix.[10] Phoenix aims to be a high-quality web framework. It provides a relatively minimal set of web-oriented features (listed in the previous section) that have a specific focus. If you want to do things it doesn't offer, it encourages you to pull in external libraries to solve those goals.

A big difference between Rails and Phoenix is the amount of "magic" in each. Magic refers to things that work in a particular way, but it's difficult to trace how exactly they work. This is also known as implicit behavior.

Rails is full of magic. This feels great in many ways, but it becomes difficult to debug problems as your application scales. Phoenix avoids magic. Whenever possible, things are done explicitly and in a way that you can trace more easily. As an example, look at how each framework handles HTTP middleware. Rails implicitly loads a default set of middleware that can be confusing to find and modify. Phoenix lists all of the middleware in `MyAppWeb.Endpoint`, so you can quickly see exactly what is running and in what order.

This chapter isn't meant to come across as "Phoenix is better than Rails." It's meant to highlight some of the differences between them so that you can decide what's best for yourself. On the surface, they share a lot of similarities, but the differences run deep and are often based on differences of opinion.

Before we can get started actually working with Phoenix, you'll need to make sure your code is ready.

Prep Your Project

We'll continue the project started in the previous chapter. Some of the code that we need to write is tedious and isn't well-suited for a book. Instead, you can copy the code from the online code listings into your project.

Book Source Code



The source code for this book can be found in its zip file on the PragProg website.[11] When you extract this zip file, you'll receive a `code` directory with subfolders under it.

10. https://dockyard.com/blog/2015/11/18/phoenix-is-not-rails
11. https://media.pragprog.com/titles/sbelixir/code/sbelixir-code.zip